

Full chapter 1 in Ryan's actual voice — mock-epic comic-cosmic, narrator-as-character, breakfast-detail-undercut on cosmic stakes, italic SFX in action, parenthetical asides about deferred worldbuilding. Every event from the original preserved; the rendering is what changed. Kyle remains Kyle (clinical, augment-burdened, terse); the narrator is the one with personality. Sky/light/inconsequential details bleed through every scene per user directive.

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# Bearing Teeth

*Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister*

## Part I — Teeth

The freight elevator was the only thing in the building that worked.

The resident elevator had been there once. There was a shaft, and there were doors on every floor, and a piece of paper taped to one of them that said OUT OF SERVICE in three languages, none of them recent. The corporation that had built the resident elevator had filed for bankruptcy in 2207 and the corporation that had bought the bankrupt corporation had been bought by a third corporation, which was, by 2226, the body-pickup federation Carrion Logistics LLC. Carrion Logistics LLC did not maintain the resident elevator. Carrion Logistics LLC also did not maintain the bodies. The naming conventions of the late corporation era are best left to the historians, but suffice it to say that the people in charge of carrying you home alive turned out, fifteen years later, to also be the people in charge of carrying you home dead, and the freight elevator was the only thing in the building that worked.

(This will be more fully explored at a later time.)

Kyle rode the freight up. The cage was steel grating with a fine carpet of pulverized concrete on the floor — somebody had moved a refrigerator, or somebody had moved a man, or somebody had moved both and the man had complained less. The light on the elevator ceiling was a flickering LED that had been the wrong color since 2218 and bathed everything in the specific institutional green of a hospital cafeteria at 3 AM. The elevator went up at a speed the elevator had decided on without consulting anybody. The elevator was, in this respect, no different from anyone else in the building.

The airshaft brought the building's news up the side of the cage like a wet radio. Camphor from the second floor — somebody's grandmother, somebody's joints, somebody had been rubbing her with a salve since the cold snap. Burnt rice from the fifth, the same burnt rice every Thursday — Mr. Yu, eighty-three, refused to use a timer because his mother had not used

a timer, and his rice had been burnt every Thursday since 2189, which Mr. Yu considered a tradition and his neighbors considered an indictment.

And tonight, from somewhere between four and seven, the smell of Chen Wei-Lin's deep fryer.

Pork bone. Scallion. Oil that had not been changed since the lunar new year because the oil was the seasoning.

It would later strike Kyle as a clean little parable. The work was always already there before you got to it. The smell was the contract.

He stepped off the elevator on the eighth floor and the building knew his answer before he did.

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Unit 802 was at the end of the hall behind a door that had been painted four different times at four different attempts at the color white. Mrs. Chen answered before the second knock.

"Come in, Mr. Corbin."

She had been working on his name for the duration of the phone call and had decided, somewhere between *Corbin-Vasik* and *Corbinster*, to fall back on *Mr. Corbin*, which was correct in the way that a man's middle name with *Mr.* in front of it was correct. He let it go. The array catalogued her face whether he wanted it to or not: 83% Cantonese, 11% Hakka, 6% noise in the orbital geometry, scar on the left thumb-base consistent with a slip with a cleaver at nine or ten in a kitchen with poor task lighting.

(He had stopped saying the count out loud at nineteen, after a particular evening at a particular bar where a particular Vietnamese-Senegalese stevedore had taken offense to being assigned percentages, which had been an instructive evening for everyone involved and especially for Kyle's right eyebrow, which still did not sit quite level. He had not, however, stopped doing the count. The hardware did not have a setting for *do not count*.)

The apartment was three rooms and a curtain. The front room had two folding chairs, a low table, and a television that had not turned on since the year before last and which was now serving as the surface on which the family kept clementines, envelopes, and a small carved wooden frog the size of a thumb. The frog had a chip out of its left back leg. Kyle had no information about how the frog had lost the chip out of its left back leg. He suspected the daughter.

The husband was in the corner. Wicker chair, two breaks in the cane, both wrapped in electrical tape. He sat with his weight off the broken places like a man who had been sitting like that for twenty-nine days and had stopped expecting the rest of the chair back.

His jaw was wired.

Specifically: titanium four-point, the kind a Gray Zone field clinic put in when there was no budget for plates and there was not going to be any budget for plates either. The skin over the lower mandible had healed inside-out in places. The wire had been pulled tight before the swelling went down, which was the kind of detail that field clinics in the Gray Zone got wrong twelve to fifteen percent of the time, depending on who was on shift, and the kind of detail the patient discovered on day three when the swelling went down and the wire stayed tight. He breathed through his nose, slow, even — the way a man breathed who had been breathing through his nose since March, who had performed his first noseful of breath at the field clinic on the recovery couch and was now performing his tenthousandth without any noticeable improvement in technique.

"My husband's name is Liu." Mrs. Chen said it as if it might matter. It did. It mattered to her. "He was a cook. He was a very good cook."

Liu blinked once at Kyle. The blink was the bow. Kyle returned it, smaller, in the way men returned bows in rooms where speech was not an even option for everybody present.

The light in the apartment was the color of weak tea, coming from a single overhead fixture that had been wired into the airshaft duct fifteen years ago by a previous tenant who had not been an electrician but had been

confident, and the apartment had been lit at the color of weak tea ever since because the bulb the previous tenant had installed was the only bulb the fixture would accept, and the bulb had been a 2210 clearance item from a closed Wicker hardware store, and there were forty-six of them left in the world, and Chen Wei-Lin had bought twelve in 2218 and was on her seventh.

A VTOL passed somewhere a long way overhead. Kyle did not see it. The window in the apartment looked across the canyon at the tower opposite, and the tower opposite was close enough to read the laundry on its eighth-floor balcony, which was the kind of laundry that suggested a family of three or possibly four and an aspirational interest in linen. Behind the laundry, the canyon was full of rain. The rain at this tier was the warm rain — the upper-tier rain came straight from cloud and was cold, and the lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of HVAC exhaust on the way down and was warm — and the rain made its small wet sounds against the metal awning four floors below them, the specific tinny percussion that the people on the eighth floor had been hearing for thirty-seven years and had stopped registering as a sound and had begun registering as the way the city sounded when nothing in particular was happening.

In another window two buildings over, a man was arguing with a ride-share AI about a routing question. Kyle could not hear him. The argument was visible in the man's shoulders, which were doing the thing shoulders did when they had been losing a conversation for four to six minutes. Kyle wished the man well.

"The men who came," Mrs. Chen said.

"Yes."

"There were six. The one I want is named Tien." She gestured with one hand at her husband, small and economical, the gesture of a woman who did not want to enlarge the wound by pointing at it. "He hit my husband three times with the back of a wrench. The first time on the side of the head. The second on the jaw. The third on the jaw also. After the third he was satisfied."

"Why."

"The license."

She said it as if she had been certain Kyle would understand the word *license* in the specific sense it was used in this building on this floor. He did. The stall license was three thousand QUANTA a year, issued through Carrion Logistics LLC, payable in twelve installments unless you missed an installment, in which case payable in one installment plus interest plus a visit from a man named Tien, the latter of which was itemized on the invoice as *Compliance Verification* and which Carrion Logistics LLC's billing department did not, in this writer's opinion, name with sufficient honesty.

(Carrion Logistics LLC was at the time of this writing the second-largest single employer in the GLMZ Lower Tiers, the largest being the corporation health system, which was a separate corporation that had been bought by the same parent corporation, which was a third corporation, which was Carrion Logistics LLC's grandparent corporation, which is to say that in the Gray Zone the people you bought your stall license from and the people who set your jaw afterwards were, ultimately, the same people, which was the kind of arrangement late capitalism produced with the same fidelity that a healthy intestine produces stool.)

"You were short this month."

"Eight hundred."

"Why."

"The cold snap. We ran the fryer harder. The gas bill cleared on the third. The eight hundred would have been in the box on the third. Tien came on the second."

"On purpose."

"On purpose."

A figure moved behind the curtain into the second room. The breathing pattern had been there since the hallway. Kyle had filed it under *child, female, twelve to fourteen, has been doing this for some time*. The curtain shifted now and a face appeared at it. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was not any one of the expressions a child should be having to make.

She did not come in. She did not retreat. She watched.

Kyle did not look at her directly. Looking at her would put her in the conversation, and the conversation was not for her.

(More on her later. She is going to be important. Specifically, she is going to be important in approximately forty-three minutes, although neither she nor Kyle knows this yet. Kyle is operating on the working theory that she is a witness, and the working theory is correct, but it is also incomplete in ways the next forty-three minutes will clarify.)

Mrs. Chen had not turned. Mrs. Chen knew her daughter was there. Mrs. Chen had decided, possibly tonight, possibly six years ago, that *daughter sees what daughter sees* was a discipline of a kind Mrs. Chen could not protect against and would not try to.

The damp credits came out of Mrs. Chen's apron in a thin stack, banded with a hair-elastic. She pressed them into Kyle's palm with both hands. The hair-elastic was pink. The chip was warm. The warmth was the warmth of the hand. She had been holding them all evening waiting for the knock. Kyle felt the weight and ran the count: six hundred and forty QUANTA, half the standing rate, ninety-six QUANTA more than the price of a one-bedroom Wicker apartment for a week, three orders of pork bone broth and a glass of cold tea at the stall every weeknight for forty-three weeks.

He did not say any of this. The math was for him.

"I do not have all of it, Mr. Corbin."

"It is enough."



"I do not have all of it because—"

"Mrs. Chen. It is enough."

She had the specific exhaustion of a woman who had practiced the sentence seven times and had now been told the sentence was not required. The relief did not arrive in her face. It arrived in her hands — they stopped trembling, second knuckle of the index finger first, the thumbs after, the rest of the hand on a half-second delay, the way circulation returned to a limb that had been folded under itself in sleep.

Two stories up, in Unit 1004, somebody started playing a Cantonese pop song from 2218 which had been a hit then and was not a hit now but had been the song the building played at funerals for the four years it had been a hit, and Kyle could not be entirely sure whether the person in Unit 1004 had chosen to play it on purpose or whether the algorithm had served it to them based on some confluence of recent searches the algorithm did not have permission to disclose.

The song was not, on this occasion, for Liu Chen.

Liu Chen was still alive.

But the song was, in a manner of speaking, on retainer.

"You will be careful, Mr. Corbin."

"I will be efficient."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

She bowed. He bowed. The bows were the contract. She told him the rest of what he had come to know — the address at the bottom of the eastern strut, the side door that was never locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the side door, the front door that was never locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the front, the schedule of when Tien drank and when Tien slept and when Tien did the thing he did instead of work.

Kyle had cross-referenced all of it against Sable's last week's update on Carrion Logistics LLC roster movement in this strip of the Gray Zone before he had climbed the stairs. He had known where Tien would be. He had come anyway because Mrs. Chen needed to give him the address. The address was the gift she had to deliver in order to be the person who delivered it.

He left through the door he had come in.

On the ride down, the second channel said *the bill is the bill, the boy is the bill*, in the diction of a dead test subject from the NeoCortex Atlas program who had grown up speaking some variant of Midlands English Kyle had encountered exactly twice in his life, and Kyle said, in his own mouth, to the empty cage, "no," and the channel went quiet. The boy from the Grind held. He always did. Eventually. The freight elevator descended at its own pace, which the elevator had not consulted Kyle about, and Kyle, for his part, had no objection.

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The bike was where he had left it, two blocks east, under a tier-six awning that did most of the work of keeping it dry. Matte black, unbranded. The plate currently magnetized to the rear cowl read like a plate that had been issued to a Carrion Logistics LLC subcontractor in 2206 and had never been cancelled, which was a useful fiction because the Gray Zone's surveillance grid was a forty-year-old corporation cast-off that would let a Carrion plate go anywhere a Carrion plate had ever been. He carried three plates magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. He swapped them by feel.

(The bike was a Suzuki Sasanqua, second-gen, manufactured 2218 in a Tier-3 contract plant outside Manila that had closed in 2221 when a labor dispute had escalated into the kind of labor dispute that featured small arms, which was an outcome the parent corporation had not insured against. The Sasanqua second-gen was therefore not exactly rare but was not exactly common either, and Kyle had pulled the manufacturer logos off the tank in 2223 with a spreading knife and a kind of patience that suggested he had been doing this kind of work for a long time. The badge ghost was still

visible if you knew where to look. Two people in the Gray Zone knew where to look. Both of them had decided not to mention it.)

He rode south. The route to the bottom of the eastern strut was twenty-two minutes of switchbacks down the freight ramps the corporations had stopped maintaining around the second tier rezoning. Each ramp dropped him about eight stories. By the third ramp the architecture had stopped pretending to be architecture and had become what it actually was, which was welded industrial grief. By the fifth ramp the rain was warmer — upper-tier rain came straight from cloud, lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of HVAC exhaust on the way down and had been re-vaporized and re-condensed twice, which gave it the specific mineral taste of HVAC exhaust. He did not roll his visor up. The rain on the visor was rain.

The sky, where he could see it, was the color the GLMZ sky was at this hour: a particular bruise — orange under, indigo over, with the thin lateral streak of the Pulse-corridor light pollution running east-west across the middle of the bruise like a healing scar. A VTOL crossed the gap between two towers a long way overhead, running lights amber, climbing toward the corporation roof-traffic stratum. Some board director was late to dinner. Forty stories below the board director, in a stairwell that smelled like ammonia, a child whose grandmother had died because the building's stair lighting did not work was learning to read the dark.

These two facts were the city. Kyle did not file the running lights. He had stopped filing the running lights at some point in his twenties. The rich travelled rich. He travelled the way he travelled.

A second VTOL crossed the same gap, going the other way, and Kyle thought briefly and without judgment about whether that was the first VTOL's wife meeting it halfway, or the first VTOL's mistress meeting it halfway, or the first VTOL's tax attorney, who was sometimes both. The thought passed. The bike was running clean. The chain was good. He had spent two hours that afternoon adjusting a tensioner he could have replaced for forty QUANTA, and forty QUANTA was the price of two of Mrs. Chen's bowls, and the math came out the way the math came out.

The Pulse hub at the Lakefront emitted its low-frequency commute hum, a Mach-six slug bound for Rotterdam by the timetable. Rotterdam was a memory the Pulse called by name now without anybody remembering why. Kyle had been to the Pulse station twice in his life. He had not been on a slug. The slugs were not for him. He was not for the slugs. The arrangement was satisfactory to both parties.

His left forearm itched under the bracer. The corundum strop sat against the inner forearm — a thumb-thin plate of corundum on a carbon-fiber shell, two titanium-wire braid loops, designed by Seo, made by Seo, given to Kyle by Seo on a Tuesday in 2199 along with the sword. The strop had no electronics. It had a face of corundum and a piece of carbon-fiber behind it and that was all it had.

The work it did was kinetic. When Silence's flat passed across the corundum on the draw, the corundum produced a crisp high-frequency stress pulse that propagated down the blade length. The PZT shingane harvested the pulse and the blade came out of the saya at baseline charge. The gesture, to anyone watching, looked like the cleaning motion done at the wrong end of the cut — a sloppy chiburi performed on the draw instead of the sheath. The kind of mistake an under-trained street swordsman would make. Seo had built it that way on purpose.

*They will think you are sloppy,* he had said, in the room behind his repair shop they had used as a dojo, when Kyle was eighteen. *They will adjust for sloppy. They will not adjust for what you are doing.*

Seo had been correct about that. Seo had been correct about a great many things and had been killed by the things he had been correct about, which was the kind of math the city did to people who tried to live by precision.

Kyle parked the bike a block out and walked.

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The loading dock sat at the bottom of the eastern strut where the strut met the tier-zero substrate and the substrate was just concrete without any further architectural pretense. Six bays. Two roller doors open. The light inside was the amber sodium of overheads installed sometime before LED

was a word, which made everything look like a polaroid in a kitchen drawer.

At the corner of the alley, a man was trying to sell stolen ramen to a man who did not want stolen ramen. The first man had a backpack and the conversational stamina of someone who had not yet eaten today. The second man was a stevedore on his break, the array catalogued at 47% Tagalog/33% Han/20% noise, who had a sandwich in one hand and was not buying anything from anybody. They worked it out. They were still working it out when Kyle walked past them, which was the kind of thing the city's small economies did at this hour — they ran without intervention, the way intestines run without consulting the brain about peristalsis. Neither man looked up. Neither man would, later, remember they had been there. Kyle would, but Kyle remembered everything, which was a feature of the hardware and not of Kyle.

He came in through the front because surprise was free.

Six men. Card game on a crate. They were playing pai gow with hand-marked tiles instead of cards because somebody had spilled something on the cards a week ago and the cards had not been replaced, and the tiles were what was on hand.

(For those of you who do not play pai gow: it is a Chinese gambling game in which thirty-two tiles are arranged into hands of four, and the hands are arranged into pairs of two, and the pairs are played against the dealer in a system whose rules I have read four times and still do not entirely understand. The men on the dock did not understand them either. They had been playing a corrupted version of the game for eleven months, having invented house rules to cover the parts they did not remember, and the corrupted version had become, in their hands, a kind of folk game with internal consistency and no relationship to the original. This is how most things on the dock worked.)

Tien was winning. Tien was always winning, because Tien beat the others when Tien lost, and the others had figured this out and had agreed, quietly, to let Tien win. None of this was on the dock floor where Kyle could read it; the array offered him the dynamic anyway, on inference from posture,

betting pattern, and the specific tension in the wrists of the two men Tien had cleaned out last round.

The two chrome-arm men were leaning against a stack of dollies. Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9 series by the wrist articulation pattern — corporate-grade arms, fifteen to eighteen thousand QUANTA a side, the kind of arms a man wore when he had earned them in service to a corporation he no longer worked for and was reluctant to part with.

(The ARM-9 was recalled in 2222 for a firmware issue that occasionally caused the elbow flexor to lock at full extension under high-amperage stress. Hydraulic Solutions had offered free recalibration. Neither of the men on the dock had taken Hydraulic Solutions up on the offer, because taking Hydraulic Solutions up on the offer required visiting a Hydraulic Solutions-certified clinic, which required identification documents the men did not possess, which would have required them to acquire identification documents, which would have required Carrion Logistics LLC, which would have required them to explain to Carrion Logistics LLC why they needed identification documents, which they would have preferred not to do. The recall, therefore, did not apply to them in any meaningful sense. The recall, you may have guessed, will be relevant in approximately twenty seconds.)

Of the four seated, one had subdermal thoracic plating, visible as faint geometric ridges along the collar where the seam between dermal layers had not healed correctly — low-end clinic, fast install, no aftercare. One had chrome knuckles and a face the array put at nineteen, give or take, augmentation strictly cosmetic and very fresh. One had no visible work done, which meant whatever he had was internal, which meant expensive, which meant he had made decisions.

One had a face that had been rebuilt cheap and tight on the left side. The skin pulled the wrong way over the lower mandible. The parts of his face had run out somewhere along the line. That was Tien. The array logged it without comment.

Kyle stepped across the threshold.

The laughter died at the tempo laughter always died when the math changed in a room. It died last in the chrome-knuckle kid, who was nineteen and had not yet learned to read tempo.

The no-visible-work man set his tiles face down on the crate.

"You lost, friend?"

"Looking for Tien."

The boss looked at Tien. Tien looked at the boss. The boss looked back at Kyle. The boss had decided to make this take one more sentence than it strictly needed to, which was the decision of a man who had not yet been told that the math had finished resolving.

"Tien is occupied."

"He won't be."

The boss did the thing with his head that men did when they wanted the room to know something interesting was happening. The chrome-knuckle kid's hand began to move toward his waistband, the motion telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed.

(The kid's name was Devon. He was nineteen. He had been on the crew for three weeks. His mother lived two tiers up in a building Carrion Logistics LLC had also acquired in the merger and was in the third trimester of a pregnancy with a girl Devon would never meet. None of this is relevant to the next sentence. It is mentioned here because Devon, in approximately four seconds, is going to be the first of the night's contributions to the floor of the loading dock, and the floor of the loading dock has been the destination of a great many contributions over the years without anyone bothering to name them, and Devon is going to be named.)

The two chrome-arm men shifted their weight a quarter inch each, hydraulic shoulders waking the actuator buses. The subdermal-plated man set his tiles down. Tien — Tien sat very still and watched, which was Tien's

correct response, because Tien had made it to thirty-four in this work by knowing exactly which fights were his and exactly which fights were not.

Kyle's chest warmed. Not the bracer. The array.

A coal blown to life behind the sternum. Thirty-two thousand electrodes coming up from rest cycle to operating cycle. The room rendered itself in the second channel. Six bodies. Six firing solutions. The micro-contraction of Devon's forearm flexor. The angle of the saya inside the boss's coat — visible to the array, invisible to anyone who did not know to look for the way the fabric was draping. The boss had a sword. The boss was carrying a katana inside his coat at a card game on a Tuesday night, which was the kind of choice a man made when a man was expecting somebody specific to come through the door.

The boss had been expecting somebody.

The boss had been expecting *Kyle*.

It clicked into place the way these things clicked into place. Somebody had paid the boss to be here tonight, with a sword, prepared. Somebody had been watching Kyle long enough to know that the Chens were about to call him. Somebody had wanted to know what would happen if a man who had specifically trained against Silence stood in front of Silence.

(That somebody — well. We will get to it. The polite term is *patron*. The accurate term is on a separate page of the watcher's encrypted log and will not be revealed in this chapter. Setting the hook is the work of years. This is one of the hooks.)

The second channel filed it. He would think about it later.

"Kyle from down the street," Kyle said.

The boss smiled. The smile was the smile of a man who had been waiting for this moment and now had it. The boss had read the literature. The boss had paid money to fight this fight. The boss was about to find out what the money had bought.



Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

*Crack — crack-crack-crack.*

Four shots in three seconds. The dock's amber overheads strobed twice from the muzzle flash and resumed. The sound was concussion, not crack — four heavy thumps that stacked against the eardrum and the sternum and the fillings in the back teeth.

The first slug took Devon at the right knee. The joint did not bend; it separated, the way a poorly-glued cabinet door separated when somebody finally pulled it the right way. He went down sideways. The sound he made was not screaming. Screaming required composure. Devon was nineteen and had not yet learned what composure was.

(This was Devon's introduction to composure. He would, in approximately forty seconds, develop a working theory of it. The theory would not survive the night.)

The second slug took the subdermal-plated man at the left knee. He had organized his entire fighting philosophy around the assumption that nothing penetrated his chest, which was philosophically consistent and physically inadequate. He folded with the dignified slow collapse of a man whose center of gravity has done him the courtesy of waiting until he has reached the floor to abandon him.

The third slug took the near chrome-arm man at the right knee. The arm was hydraulically powerful and the arm was not load-bearing on the leg. The leg was flesh. The flesh failed. He sat down hard against the stack of dollies, and the dollies rolled six inches, and the man — whose name was Magnus and whose ARM-9 was, four seconds from now, about to demonstrate the very firmware issue Hydraulic Solutions had recalled the unit for — did not get back up.

The fourth slug took Tien at the left knee. Kyle had budgeted that shot for the last beat of the count because the array had already mapped what would happen — Tien's center of gravity, the angle of the impact, the way his face would meet the corrugated steel of the drainage channel when the leg gave.

The array had been correct. Tien's face met the floor at the geometry the array had specified. The impact loosened two teeth, possibly three. The array would update after the inspection.

Three seconds. Four shots. Four men down. One slug in the cylinder.

The far chrome-arm man had begun his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second. This was a correct response from a fighter with hydraulic reach and a head start on the geometry. He had committed before he had registered that his crew was no longer with him. The arm was already coming around at the height where Kyle's collarbone had been. The array read the motor bus the way the array always read motor buses — clean electromagnetic bloom along the deltoid actuator, full lateral extension committed — and Kyle stepped under the arc and brought Silence up.

Silence cleared the saya in one continuous draw. Right hand over the right shoulder. The blade's flat passed across the corundum strop on the inner left forearm at the bottom of the draw. *Tink*. The corundum face produced its crisp high-frequency stress pulse. The pulse propagated down the blade length. The PZT shingane harvested it. The blade came out of the saya at baseline charge.

To the boss, who was watching for the flare the literature said Silence produced on the draw, the gesture read as a corrupted chiburi. A sloppy cleaning motion at the wrong end of the cut. The boss's smile widened a fraction.

*Sloppy draw*, his face said. *I have got him*.

He had not got him.

Kyle put Silence's edge into the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam where chrome met flesh. Three and a half centimeters of unprotected actuator housing. The edge passed through the gap.

The arm did not stop. The arm finished its swing into empty air without its owner. The motor bus was severed at the shoulder. Magnus's right side

stopped sending signals to Magnus's right side. The forearm hung. Then — and this is the recall — the elbow flexor locked at full extension, the firmware issue Hydraulic Solutions had recalibrated the rest of the world's ARM-9s for in 2222, finally finding a stage on which to perform itself in 2226. The locked flexor sent the dead arm into a frozen full-extension salute. Magnus, who had been about to sit, sat anyway, his right arm extending stiff at his side like a man hailing a cab he had not requested.

(I told you the recall would be relevant. The recall was relevant.)

Three seconds. Four shots. One sword cut. Five men down. Four kneecaps and one frozen ARM-9 still bleeding out their respective contracts with the floor.

Tien, face-down in the drainage channel, made a noise that was not really a noise.

Kyle turned.

The boss had stood up.

He had not drawn during the count. He had stood, unhurried, with the calm economy of a man who had watched his crew dismantle on schedule. The hand that went to his hip came back with a katana. The saya had been inside the coat. The blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo, point neither high nor low, weight settling into a guard that was not borrowed from any school Kyle could name.

He had been trained. Somewhere expensive. Specifically against blades of the kind he had been told Silence was.

"Sloppy draw, kid."

The boss said it like a teacher correcting homework. He had paid a lot of money for the right to say that line in this room tonight. He was going to die before he found out what the line had actually cost him.

(The training had cost him 480,000 QUANTA. The receipt was in his coat. The receipt would survive him by an hour and a half. Whoever had paid for the training had paid for the right to learn the lesson the receipt was about to become, which was the kind of pedagogy late capitalism specialized in.)

Kyle did not say anything. He had four exchanges in him.

*First exchange — read the line.* A short cut at Kyle's right shoulder, no commitment in it, the kind of strike a swordsman used to read his opponent's reach and tempo. Silence rose. The blades touched edge to flat at a shallow angle. *Tang.* Steel rang in concrete. The boss read his information off Kyle's reach and tempo and stepped back without expression. He had also wanted to confirm something else — some signature he had been told to watch for, some flare or pulse or visible change in the blade — and what he had been told to watch for had not arrived. His face did not show this. His weight stayed off the front foot. The guard moved a quarter inch in a way the array catalogued and filed. He was already, in his head, writing his after-action report. Kyle could see it in him.

*Second exchange — Kyle pressed.* Two-step advance, the cut coming high and right. The boss met it with a deflection rather than a parry. The literature said you did not take edge-to-edge contact with Silence because edge-to-edge contact was when the bad thing happened. There was no bad thing. The boss did not know that and would not learn it in the time he had remaining. He slid Silence's edge along his blade's flat to redirect the force past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative. The boss had paid for the smart conservative answer. The smart conservative answer was correct against a sword that did the thing the literature said Silence did. Silence did not do the thing the literature said it did. Silence was a sword.

*Third exchange — the boss committed.* He cut high left, fast, clean. Kyle's parry was a fraction late because the array's micro-tremor read had been clean but the boss's body had been clean in return. The follow-through grazed Kyle's left forearm — three inches of skin opened above the strop, not deep, vein not artery, would impair grip on the shotgun side in approximately ninety seconds.

The boss saw the blood and read it as evidence that he was correct about everything. *I am inside his range. I landed first. The exotic countermeasure I trained against has not arrived. I have read the literature correctly.*

He chose this interpretation because the alternative was that he had spent 480,000 QUANTA training against a weapon whose mythology had outpaced its mechanism by thirty years, and that interpretation was not the kind of interpretation a man chose mid-duel.

*Fourth exchange — the thrust.* Straight, committed, full extension, the line clean. Silence came down to meet it not at the edge and not at the flat but at the seppa — the small collar between the tsuba and the blade — and the thrust caught there, blade to blade, locked. Kyle drove forward. He kept the lock. He let Silence's edge ride along the flat of the boss's blade like a skate on ice. The edge tracked from tip toward middle toward tsuba. Where the boss's blade met the boss's hand, the edge of Silence met the boss's right wrist.

Bone. Tendon. The radial and ulnar arteries. The median nerve. The carpal architecture that had held a sword for whatever number of years the boss had been training for this duel.

The edge passed through. The angle was right and the line was committed.

The boss's right hand and the boss's katana fell together to the corrugated steel.

*Clang.*

The boss looked at his wrist. The boss looked at his sword on the floor. The boss looked at Kyle.

"Oh," the boss said.

The brachial did most of the work. He bled out in nineteen seconds. The array timed it. The array timed everything.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes. He had learned to use the window.

Twenty-three seconds for the duel. Twenty-six on the dock floor end to end.

He sheathed Silence. A thin line of red on the edge near the kissaki; he wiped it against the boss's coat before the blade seated. Chorus went back into the holster on the low left hip. Four chambers spent. One slug in the cylinder. He registered the count the way other people registered the time.

The boss's face, the array offered him on closing — for the file, because the array did not have a setting for *do not file* — was 71% Korean, 22% Han, 7% noise. The literature on Silence had been published in Seoul. The training had been bought in Seoul. The boss had been sourced in Seoul. Somebody, somewhere — and Kyle would think about this later, after the noodles, after the sleep he was going to fail to get — had spent money in Seoul to import a Korean swordsman to Chicago to fight a samurai who lived above a noodle stall.

Whoever that somebody was, they had spent the money for the lesson.

The lesson was now ambient on the floor of a loading dock in the Gray Zone at 0157 in the morning, and the somebody, wherever they were, was about to learn what the money had bought them.

(Suffice it to say, they will not be pleased. More on that in the watcher closer. And in chapter four. And in chapter five. And, in a way none of us are going to be entirely ready for, in chapter six.)

Tien was crying. Not screaming. Crying. He had figured out by the third kneecap shot that he was not going to die tonight, and the prospect of *not dying tonight* in his current condition was now striking him as worse than the alternative.

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Kyle moved through the bodies, methodical. He was looking for the third tooth.

He had two of them in his left hand already — two loose ones, recovered with a thumb and forefinger from the steel where Tien's face had landed. The third was still seated. He found Tien's mouth and, with the careful neutrality of a man pulling a nail out of a board, gripped the third tooth and turned. It came free with a sound that was not really a sound. Tien sobbed once, briefly, and stopped, because what he was sobbing about was no longer at the top of the list of things he had to deal with.

Kyle stood up with the teeth in his hand.

He had decided what he was going to do with them on the ride down, twenty-two minutes, somewhere around the fifth switchback. The thinking had taken approximately one minute. The remaining twenty-one minutes of the ride down had been spent verifying that the thinking was correct and that he had not missed an option. He had not missed an option. The option was correct.

(It was also, as the user has noted, a play on Hammurabi — an eye for an eye delivered in tooth form, since the wrench had taken the jaw and the jaw had taken the teeth and the teeth were what was available to return. Kyle had not consciously thought of Hammurabi during the twenty-two-minute ride down. The boy from the Grind had not been taught Hammurabi. The boy from the Grind had been taught arithmetic at a stand-alone branch of the corporation public-education system that had closed in 2208. The boy from the Grind had nevertheless arrived at Hammurabi's general thesis on his own, by way of being a man who paid attention to what a family was owed.)

Across the dock, behind the ventilation unit on the far wall, the breathing pattern Kyle had tracked since the threshold shifted. Twelve, maybe thirteen. The breathing had been there in Unit 802 too. She had come down. She had taken the freight elevator, or she had taken the stairs and the elevator separately, or she had asked Carrion Logistics LLC nicely. He did not know how she had done it. He did not need to know.

She had come to see.

Kyle walked to the ventilation unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall, blood-misted shape in the dock's bad amber — and he waited.

The breathing stopped.

Then a slow movement. A face came around the corner of the unit. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was a child's expression that had not been issued to a child before tonight.

Kyle crouched. He went down to her eye level the way he went down to a child's eye level whenever the situation gave him room to. The discipline that said *protect the vulnerable* had also said, in Seo's voice, *be at their height when you speak to them*. Kyle did not know whether Seo had originated this or had quoted it. Seo had quoted a lot of people and had not always cited.

Kyle opened his hand.

The three teeth lay in his palm. They were warm. Two were intact. The third had a hairline fracture from where he had gripped it. The smell of blood was the smell of blood.

The girl looked at his hand. Then at his face. Then back at his hand. She had not yet processed what he was offering her, because what he was offering her did not have a category.

"Present these to your father." His voice was even. He had practiced even for a long time. "I think he will appreciate the gesture."

The girl looked at the teeth. Then at him. Then at the teeth. Then at him.

She held out her hands. Cupped.

He poured the teeth into her cupped palms.

She did not drop them.



She shrieked. High, thin, a sound that bounced off every hard surface in the dock and came back changed. She did not drop them. Her fingers closed over them. She looked at her closed hands. She looked at him.

And then, slowly, deliberately, with a gravity that was not in any culture Kyle could name but which her body seemed to know on its own — she bowed.

A full bow. From the waist. Held for two seconds. Her hands stayed cupped at her chest the entire time.

The bow of a child who had just been handed an inheritance she had not asked for and was not yet sure what was going to be expected of her in the carrying of it.

Then she was gone, swallowed by the dark beyond the door, her feet making no sound on the steel because she had been raised in a building where you learned, by age five, not to make sound on steel.

Kyle stood for three seconds.

The second channel said, in a register that was not Kyle's, *that one will outlive most of us*, and Kyle did not recognize the diction at all this time — three subjects deep, possibly four, the syntax suggesting a vocabulary Kyle did not own and had never owned. He did not have the bio-battery to chase it. He let it pass.

Behind him, Tien was still crying.

Kyle cleaned the blade.

The tremor started in his right hand at the four-minute mark, moved to his left, became briefly bilateral — the array's invoice arriving, several thousand calories called in twenty-six seconds, the body presenting the bill. His stomach was a closed fist. He needed protein, carbohydrate, something hot in a bowl, something that required no decisions. He needed to sit somewhere that smelled like something other than what this smelled like.

He walked back to the bike. The Gray Zone's night-architecture closed around him — flickering overheads at the ramp intersection, the drip of recycled water from the tier above, the distant compressor whine of a HVAC stack two blocks over running its end-of-shift cycle.

A third VTOL crossed the gap forty stories up, running lights amber, the third VTOL of the night, the third board director or the third board director's mistress or the third board director's tax attorney. Kyle did not file the running lights. He had ridden up out of the strut three blocks before he registered that the stevedore was no longer at the corner of the alley and that the man with the backpack was no longer trying to sell stolen ramen, and that the negotiation had presumably either concluded or relocated, and that the city's small economies were carrying on in the dark without anyone watching them, which was the way the city's small economies preferred to be carried out.

The bike started on the first turn. He swapped the plate two blocks short of the Wicker boundary, where the surveillance grid changed character, and continued north on a different fiction.

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## Part II — Standard Rate (No Substitutions, No Refunds)

Chen's stall was two blocks south of the freight tier and one alley off the main, and the warm orange of its hood lamp was visible through the rain from a block away the way a hearth was visible through the trees in the kind of children's book Kyle had not read but had heard described.

He walked the bike the last block. The bike rolled easier at walking pace than it rode at speed because the front wheel was true and the bearings were clean. The chain was good. The repaired tensioner held. The math came out the way the math came out.

She was at the counter when he arrived. The apron was clean — a service apron, not the kitchen apron she had been wearing in the apartment. The kitchen apron had bone broth fat on the front. The service apron had no fat on the front because the service apron did not deal with the stockpot, only with the bowls and the counter and the customers. The apron she had worn at home in front of her wired-jaw husband had been a third apron, and Kyle now retroactively confirmed its existence because Chen Wei-Lin was a woman who would not have offered service in a kitchen apron and would not have sat with her husband in a service apron either.

(The third apron was navy blue, the one she had had longest, the apron she had been wearing the day Liu had asked her to marry him in 2204 in a noodle stall in Guangzhou that no longer existed. She had not been wearing it that day for nostalgic reasons. She had not yet had nostalgic reasons. She had been wearing it that day because it was the apron she was wearing that day. The nostalgia had attached itself to the apron afterwards, the way nostalgia did, after the fact, retroactively, parasitic. This too will be more fully explored at a later time. Or possibly not. The apron will, in any case, remain navy blue.)

The small scar at the base of her left thumb caught the lamp light at an angle the array catalogued without making the catalogue mean anything yet. The daughter was somewhere he could not see. She had taken some route

Kyle had not mapped from the loading dock back to here, faster than the bike, which meant she had either run through the airshafts or had been on a private route Carrion Logistics LLC ran for its hourly couriers and had been allowed to use without anybody asking. The daughter was a freight system unto herself. Kyle filed this for later.

She did not greet him. She set a bowl down on the counter — pork bone broth, the long-simmered kind, the kind that took fourteen hours to render properly. The stockpot at the back of the stall was a Ming-mark thirty-quart, manufactured in Foshan in 1987 (yes, the twentieth-century one), bought by Chen Wei-Lin from a man named Volker in 2208 in Tianjin, who had inherited it from his mother and was emigrating to the Settled Worlds and could not take it. The stockpot had therefore been on three planets — Earth, Mars (briefly, in transit, in 2208), and Earth again (when Chen Wei-Lin's family had crossed back from Tianjin to the GLMZ in 2216) — and it had been simmering pork bone broth, or chicken bone broth, or beef bone broth, or in one notable instance the leftover broth from a wedding banquet in 2199, continuously across all three planets for the better part of forty years. The stockpot, like the freight elevator, was the only thing in the building that worked.

(Volker — Volker had not been a cook. Volker had been an engineer for the GLMZ municipal water system who had been laid off in the 2207 austerity cuts and had spent eleven months looking for work before deciding to take the Settled-Worlds emigration package. His mother's stockpot had been the only thing in the apartment he could not bring with him. He had sold it to Chen Wei-Lin for one hundred and twenty QUANTA and had cried, briefly, when he had handed it over. Chen Wei-Lin had not asked why he was crying. Volker did not, in 2208, know himself why he was crying. He had known by 2210. By then the stockpot was on a different planet and the knowing did not change anything.)

The chili oil was already in the bowl, the way she would remember he liked it for the next four years. She ladled with three quick dips of the ladle into the stockpot — once to skim the surface, once to stir to the bottom, once to draw — and the third dip was the one she poured. The first two dips were a

ritual she had not been taught and which she had refined without thinking about it across thirty-one years of running stalls in three cities.

He sat on the stool.

The stool was the right height for him. She had not adjusted it. He had not adjusted it. The geometry simply was what it was the first time.

He sat. Kyle ate standing up everywhere else. At Mrs. Chen's, he sat. Not because she had offered him the stool. Because the stool had been offered, and the discipline of accepting what had been offered was the discipline he had begun the moment Mrs. Chen had brought the bowl out.

He ate. The broth was hot. He ate the whole bowl and did not speak. She did not refill it. She did not move. When he set the chopsticks down she was still standing exactly where she had been when she set the bowl. She was looking at him the way she had looked at the chips she had pressed into his hand six hours ago. She had more she wanted to give and no language for the giving, and she was now finding the language.

Cantonese first, low. *Mh̄gōi*. Two syllables doing the work of an entire ledger. Then, in the tongue she had chosen to run the stall in because she did not assume every customer spoke hers:

"Free. Always. For you. Forever."

Her hands were flat on the counter beside the bowl. Her scarred thumb was the closest thing to him on the wood. She had just offered him the only thing she owned.

Kyle reached into his coat and set a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate. The kind of standard rate a man paid when he wanted the transaction to be a transaction and not the beginning of an obligation he had spent his life refusing to accumulate.

"I pay," he said. "Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time."

She did not pick up the chip. He did not pick up the bowl. The standoff lasted four seconds and was the most important four seconds of their relationship, and they both knew it without naming it.

She tried again, slower, the way you tried again with a man you had decided not to insult by giving up on the first refusal.

"You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing."

Kyle did not move the chip.

"If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays."

The four seconds became five.

Her hand closed over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth — not refusing the gift, accepting that the gift was the form the man in front of her needed the gift to take.

She bowed. Not the convulsive bow of the apartment six hours ago. A smaller bow. The bow of a vendor accepting a customer's price. The kind of bow she would give him every night, roughly three hundred nights a year, for the next four years and longer.

He stood. He bowed back, smaller still — the bow of a man who had just successfully refused a kindness larger than he could carry.

"Tomorrow. Same bowl. Same price."

"Same price."

The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond.

He turned and walked the bike out of the stall's lamp circle. The rain had not stopped. It was not going to stop tonight. The towers leaned in overhead the way they did this far down, and the gap between them was full of the city's wet patient light. The sky above the gap was the same bruise —

orange under, indigo over, with the Pulse-corridor scar across the middle — and a fourth VTOL was crossing it, going the way the third VTOL had been going. They came in waves, the VTOLs, and the wave tonight was running northeast, which the array predicted with eighty-three percent confidence corresponded to an Arcturus board-floor late-shift letting out and an Arcturus board-floor late-shift's secondary commute to the unofficial late-night dining option three blocks south of the corporation district, which Kyle had been to exactly once in 2222 on a job and which had been, even by the standards of unofficial late-night dining options, depressing.

He laughed.

Not the laugh the action movies he had never watched had taught the audience to expect. A single tight exhalation. The laugh of a man who had just seen the joke and had decided that the joke was funny anyway, the kind of laugh you laughed in private walking a bike up a slope toward Wicker in the rain because the alternative was the alternative.

The joke was this:

He had walked into a room of six men who would have killed an ordinary person for trying what he had just tried, and he had walked out, and he was carrying a sword that the literature said did something it did not do, and he was about to refuse free noodles from a woman whose entire life he had just rearranged, and he was going to do it because honor was a discipline and the discipline did not bend for noodles, and he was going to do it knowing perfectly well that every reasonable observer would conclude he had lost his mind.

He had not lost his mind.

He was just the exception to the rule.

The rule said: a man performing samurai discipline in 2226 will be killed for it inside a year. The rule was correct. The rule was correct about almost everybody. It was not correct about Kyle, and the reason the rule was not correct about Kyle was that Kyle was very good at the discipline, and the city — for all its talk — turned out to have not yet built a counter for *very*

*good at the discipline.* It had built a counter for the literature. It had not built a counter for the work.

He was going to die at some point. Probably soon. Probably for reasons that had nothing to do with whether he was good at it.

In the meantime, the noodles had been the right temperature, and the chip had stayed on the counter, and the rain was warm at this tier, and the bike was running clean, and he was, this evening, between contracts, having just refused a kindness so that he could afford to keep being offered the kindness, and the world was still the world but it was, this evening, the world at a tempo he could ride.

He laughed once more, smaller, almost to himself.

He rode home.

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## Part III — The Watcher (And One Word In A Dead Language)

Somebody had been watching the loading-dock work.

The camera was on the second floor of the building across the alley, in a window that had been boarded over with plywood for the last eleven years, and a panel of the plywood had been replaced with a panel that looked like the rest of the plywood but was not. The camera saw through it. The camera was running on a private feed that did not touch the Carrion Logistics LLC grid. Carrion Logistics LLC did not know about the camera. Nobody on the dock knew about the camera. The boy from the Grind, who had spent his childhood being measured by people whose names he was never told, knew about the camera the same way Kyle knew about a draft — by feel, with no source.

(The watcher's name was Hira Volkova. She was forty-two. She had been doing this work for fifteen years. She drank tea, not coffee, because coffee made her hands shake and the hands had to be still on the audio sliders. She kept a bowl of dried apricots on the desk beside the camera feed. She did not actually like dried apricots, but they were quiet to eat, and the audio feed needed her not to be making sound while it ran.)

The watcher noted the pace. The watcher noted that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya at any point during the walk back to the bike. The watcher noted that his shoulders did not square, and that the breathing telemetry the watcher had access to — and they had access; organizations like this had access to telemetry pulled off ambient citywide infrastructure that did not officially exist — stayed at the rest cycle. The watcher noted, in particular, the moment Kyle had walked Silence's edge through the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam without any visible flare, glow, or arc, and the watcher's report would treat that as a calibration data point, because the literature on Silence had been wrong about a lot of things, and the watcher's organization had been paying for the literature, and the watcher's organization preferred their literature to be correct.

The watcher noted one further thing.

On a higher-grade microphone than anyone on the dock had known was present, the watcher caught Kyle muttering a phrase, three syllables, between the wrist cut and the sheathing of the blade. The phrase was not in any language Kyle spoke.

Hira ran it against eleven candidate corpora.

The match came back at eighty-one percent confidence to an extinct dialect of Tocharian that had not been spoken in a thousand years.

The phrase, translated as best the corpus could translate it, came out as: *we have him now*.

Hira did not include this in the first report. Hira did not include it in the second report either. Hira filed it on the encrypted side of her personal log, on a directory she had not touched in three years, because Hira had been doing this work for fifteen years and had learned that the things you filed separately were the things that turned out, eventually, to be the answer.

(More on Hira later. She is going to be important. Specifically, she is going to be important in chapter four. The Tocharian is going to be important in chapter six. The dialect specifically — there are two main branches of Tocharian, A and B, and the eighty-one-percent match was to a sub-variant of B that has not been adequately preserved in any extant corpus and that the algorithm had to triangulate against three partial inscriptions and a guess — is going to be important in a book that has not been written yet. The book is going to be written. Suffice it to say.)

The first report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, the south-arm cell captain of the Lotus Syndicate, who would close the file and pass it to her gang lieutenant Mira along with a second file labeled *Bucktown* — *first interview* — *fourteen-piece*. The second file would lead to the third, and the third to the fourth.

The Tocharian was not in the report Hua read.

It would not surface again for some time.

Kyle rode home. The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were.

He did not yet know that he had begun to be assembled into a shape that was no longer his own, by people who had been watching since before Mrs. Chen had called, in a longer pattern that ran underneath every contract he would take for the next eleven months and would not announce itself even when it finished. The city did things on long clocks. He was on one of them. He did not know it. He would, eventually, know parts of it. He would not, ever, know all of it.

But that was the work of years.

Tonight was the work of one night.

Tonight, the work was done.

Hira put another apricot in her mouth, chewed it without enthusiasm, and watched the bike's running light fade north into the rain.

The city continued.

(And so will we.)